PRINTMAKING HAS BEEN FOUNDATIONAL TO SHEIKH'S PRACTICE. HIS ENGAGEMENT WITH IT EXTENDS BEYOND THE STUDIO INTO LEARNING FROM ARTISTS ACROSS THE WORLD

that all of his various interests seemed to converge in these magazines, in the earlier days."

But printmaking has always been foundational to Sheikh's practice. In fact, he even studied it at the institution where he later taught, and continues to engage with it even today, picking up a plate on a whim to do some of his etchings, as one would doodle. For Sheikh, his engagement with this medium extends beyond his studio, into learning from artists from across the world. "There was a specific period when we began looking seriously at major printmakers, and the work of the Japanese woodblock master Shiko Munakata, whose prints made a deep impression on me. I also studied European printmaking, particularly the work of artists from the decades after Cubism," Sheikh says.

The second part of the exhibition, titled *Mind Prints*, showcases Sheikh's striking engagement with digital printmaking since 2001, when he first encountered computers as an artistic tool at the erstwhile ARTunderground gallery's New Media Art workshop in Baroda. The title follows the artist's logic that, in digital art, the machine replaces the hands with the mind, making the mind crucial to finding, composing and making images. These works have distinctly saturated colours and explore themes that play with space and time, drawing inspiration from Kabir and the Ebstorf Mappamundi (a medieval European map of the world) to Mughal miniatures, Renaissance painting and world cinema.

What stood out for Pushpamala in this regard was Sheikh's curiosity, compared with that of his contemporaries, who were mostly purists and hesitant to try new technology. It's also what allowed him to blur the lines between painting and digital printmaking. "He sees a different kind of opportunity in this, and starts painting on these digital prints. And not only that, sometimes he would paint a background, scan it, and then work on it digitally," Pushpamala says. Sheikh constantly moves between mediums—painting, scanning, digitally manipulating and painting again.

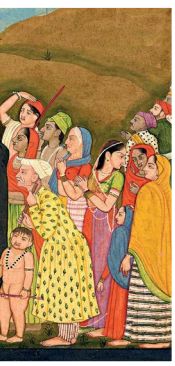
Soon after starting out on digital, Sheikh realised how seductive technology can be, and had to consciously rein in his urge to use every tool at his disposal. "It was offering me options before my own knowledge, and it had the potential to influence my way of thinking," he says.

Immediately after, and almost inadvertently, the artist cautions youngsters against being charmed by what's on their screens. "Technology gives you options; it does not necessarily help you think," Sheikh says, underlining what truly defines an artist to this day. ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on display till Aug. 2





VIEW FROM THE HILLS
Clockwise from left: 'Krishna and his family admire a solar eclipse' (c. 1775-1780); 'Hemla Ragaputra', folio from a Ragamala series (c. 1700) and 'Jarasandha's army advances towards Krishna and Balarama' (c. 1800-1815)

imagery and emotional depth. Combining Mughal influences with local devotional traditions, artists produced intricate works depicting Hindu epics, romance and sacred landscapes.

Curator Debra Diamond describes the paintings as "swoon-worthy", noting that artists used opaque watercolours made from ground pigments, gold and even beetle wings to create radiant surfaces. Many works in the exhibition come from the Benkaim Collection, acquired by the museum in 2017 and 2018. The show also includes paintings from the Cleveland Museum of Art. "Together with other works from our museum's rich South Asian and Himalayan collections, they allow us to deepen our understanding of Indian culture and pursue new avenues of scholarship," says Chase F. Robinson, director of the National Museum of Asian Art.

The exhibition examines how artists helped shape ideas of the Himalaya as a sacred landscape. Inspired by texts such as the *Bhagavata Purana* and poetic traditions centred on Krishna, love and longing, the paintings possess an emotional intensity that continues to resonate today. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The exhibition is on view till Jul. 26